Creative Brief

Lydia Park
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Project Title: Hare of the Woods, a Cottontail Rabbit Website

1. Project overview

The goal of my website is to be informational, but to present cottontail rabbits the way a good field guide would: calm, organized, and easy to look through. Most people see cottontails in their yard and don't think twice about them, so I want the site to show that there are actually 27 different species spread across the Americas, each adapted to its own place.

2. Resources

Copy is available at https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Cottontail_rabbit, including the full species list and ranges. Photography and range maps can come from Wikimedia Commons, and every image will be credited on the Sources page. My content outline lists what goes on each page.

3. Goals

- Make the 27 species easy to browse and compare, with the Species Guide as the main feature of the site.
- Keep facts short and scannable, with key numbers pulled out instead of buried in paragraphs.
- Work well on phones, tablets, and desktops, and meet basic accessibility (readable contrast, alt text, keyboard-friendly nav).

4. Audience

This is a strictly informational site and won't be promoted commercially. It will be part of my portfolio, so my instructors and classmates will review it, and prospective employers may see it too. Beyond that, the audience is curious adults and students, people who have noticed a rabbit in their yard and want to know more. Readers shouldn't need any science background.

5. Message

The cottontail is one of the most common animals people see, but it is more interesting than it looks. I want people to leave knowing that "cottontail" is a whole group of species, how they survive by listening and staying hidden, and how much they vary from the swamps of the southern US to the mountains of South America.

6. Tone

Gentle, curious, and a little quiet, like flipping through a nature journal. It should feel warm and approachable, not cartoonish or cutesy. I'm not trying to make it a pet care site or a kids' site. The writing should be clear and friendly, and the design should give the content room to breathe.

7. Site structure

Seven pages: Home, Meet the Cottontail, Where They Live, Staying Alive, Growing Up, Species Guide, and Sources. Navigation across the top on desktop, collapsing into a menu on mobile. Each page opens with one large photo and a short intro, then breaks into smaller sections. The Species Guide uses a grid of cards that goes from one column on phones to three or four on desktop.

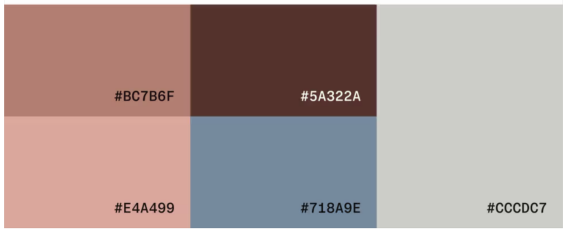
8. Visual Style

I want a soft field guide feel: muted, natural colors pulled from the cottontail itself (warm browns, dusty pinks like the inside of the ears, and soft grays and blues like early morning). Lots of off-white space, thin lines, and small labels, like the notes in a naturalist's sketchbook. Scientific names should always be in italics, the way they would be in a printed guide.

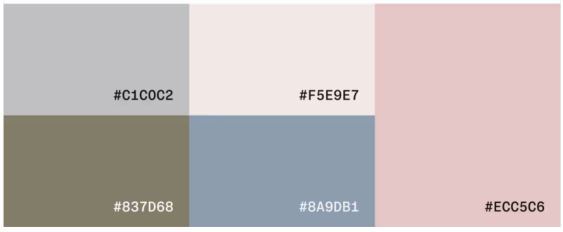
Typography: a soft serif for headings (something like Fraunces) and a clean sans-serif for body text (something like Work Sans), both from Google Fonts. Small uppercase labels for things like range and subgenus.

Photography: natural photos of cottontails in grass and brush, not studio or pet photos. Close-ups of ears, eyes, and the white tail could work as detail shots between sections.

Color: here are my two palettes. The light pink (#F5E9E7) works as the page background, the dark brown (#5A322A) for text and headings, and the dusty pinks, slate blues, and olive (#837D68) for cards, section backgrounds, and accents. The lighter colors should stay as backgrounds so text stays readable.



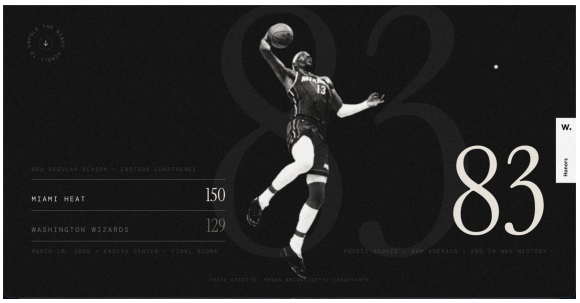
Palette 1: warmer colors, for headings, text, and accents



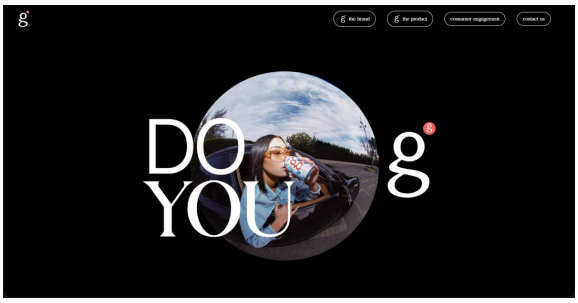
Palette 2: softer colors, for backgrounds, cards, and section breaks

Layout inspiration

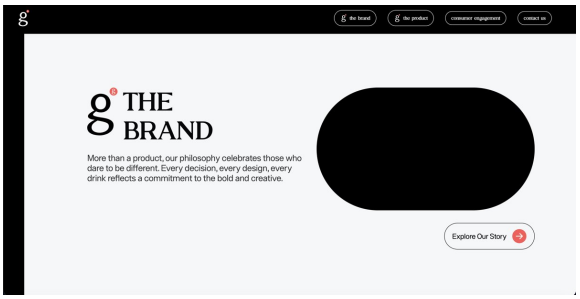
I want the photography to be big and editorial, not just small pictures next to text. These sites all treat one image as the main event and let the type work around it. I'd like something in the same direction, but lighter and softer to fit my palette.



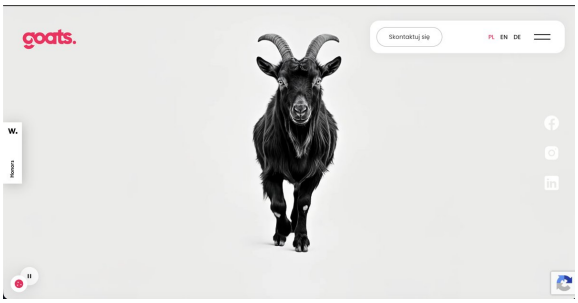
A cutout photo layered over a giant serif number, with small spaced-out labels. I could do this with a cottontail over a huge "27" for the 27 species (but on a light background, not so dark).



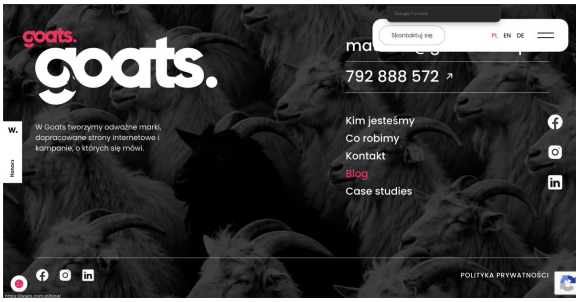
Big headline type overlapping a circle-cropped photo. Could work for the home page hero.



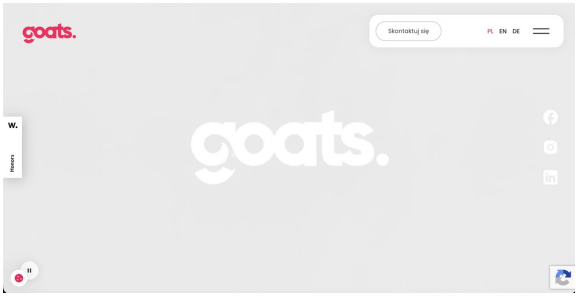
Heading and text on one side, a pill-shaped image on the other, and rounded pill buttons. A good pattern for the inside pages.



One animal cut out and centered on a plain light background, very calm and simple. This is close to the field guide feel I want for the Species Guide.



A full-bleed, darkened photo of a whole group of animals with white type on top. Could be the footer or the Sources page (but in dark brown instead of black).



The same site opens with a huge white logo fading in over soft gray. A quiet title moment like this could open my home page before the photo shows up.